

Voyages of discovery

In the 15th century, an age of discovery began, with explorers setting off on long sea journeys. The earliest voyages were made by the Chinese in the early 1400s. Later, European explorers searching for a new sea route to Asia found America instead.

KEY

Zheng He's seven voyages, 1405–1433.

Christopher Columbus's voyage, 1492.

Vasco da Gama's voyage, 1497–1498.

John Cabot's voyage, 1497.

Ferdinand Magellan's voyage, 1519–1521.

Hoping to reach Asia, Columbus sailed the *Santa Maria* to the Caribbean.

John Cabot sailed the *Matthew* to North America.

John Cabot, like Columbus, hoped to get to Asia by sailing west in 1497.

The *Matthew*

John Cabot

ENGLAND

SPAIN

PORTUGAL

NORTH AMERICA

The *Santa Maria*

ATLANTIC OCEAN

SOUTH AMERICA

Mapping the world

This map shows what Europeans thought the world looked like in 1491. Europe is on the left and Asia is on the right. There is no America because Europeans had not discovered it yet.

15th-century map

São Gabriel

Vasco da Gama sailed to India and back in the *São Gabriel*.

SOUTHERN OCEAN

PACIFIC OCEAN